

[Return to Search](#)

The forest people

**Author(S):** Turnbull, Colin M.

**Document Type:** Book

**Original Page:** 44

**Culture (OWC):** [Mbuti \(FO04\)](#)

**Region:** Africa

**Sub Region:** Central Africa

**Field Date:** 1951, 1957, 1958

**Coverage Date:** Not Specified

**Place Coverage:** Not Specified

**Section Title(S):** 2 The Good Death Of Balekimito

Rather to my surprise this struck the Pygmies as being funny, and they began sniggering. Kenge, carefully dusting the last specks of earth from his spotless shorts, pretended to be severe and said this was no time for laughter. He then promptly cracked a joke at the expense of the Negroes and joined his friends in howls of mirth. When Pygmies laugh it is hard not to be affected; they hold onto one another as if for support, slap their sides, snap their fingers, and go through all manner of physical contortions. If something strikes them as particularly funny they will even roll on the ground, but this time the disapproving looks they got from the Negroes discouraged them.

177  
[Acculturation And Culture Contact](#)

201  
[Gestures And Signs](#)

522  
[Humor](#)

764  
[Burial Practices And Funerals](#)

The Negroes, having restored order, went on to the business of settling who was responsible for the death of the child. To them no death is natural; some evil spirit, some witch or sorcerer, had cursed the girl with dysentery and made her die. They tried to find out who had been fighting in Cephu's camp, who were the enemies of the girl's family. Their concern was a real one, for if the witch was not found, it might strike at them next. But the Pygmies were not co-operative. They were bored and listless. The girl had died and that was that. The Negroes finally gave up and we all returned, washing from head to foot as we crossed over the Nepussi.

177  
Acculturation And  
Culture Contact

522  
Humor

761  
Life And Death

764  
Burial Practices And  
Funerals

Back in the main camp everything was normal. Only in Cephu's little camp was there quiet, subdued wailing from the house of the child's parents. There was some discussion as to whether or not the molimo should be called out. Cephu said in an aggressive manner that it should be, the only trouble being that he didn't have one. Certain families own them; others do not but when in need can borrow them from relatives. Cephu promptly called on Njobo, who reluctantly agreed.

765  
Mourning

That night, after the evening meal, a small number of men from the main camp went over to Cephu's camp and sat down around the central fire. The women and children were in their huts; some  45 talking, some sleeping, some sobbing softly. The men started singing, and after a while I heard their song echoed from far off in the forest and recognized the wistful sound, hollow and ghostly, answering the men with snatches of their own song, sometimes singing its own variations, sometimes breaking off into low, growling, animal noises. The men continued singing as though nothing were happening, and I heard the molimo coming closer, circling around the camp. The women were all quiet in their huts now, and the fire had burned low; the camp was pitch dark except for an occasional glow where the ashes of some family hearth still glowed faintly outside a hut. Even near a village, Cephu never built huts in imitation of the Negroes, and his camp was a typical forest camp, a close little circle of small conical huts, made of a framework of saplings covered entirely with leaves.

177  
Acculturation And  
Culture Contact

342  
Dwellings

361  
Settlement Patterns

765  
Mourning

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  [hraf@yale.edu](mailto:hraf@yale.edu)

Issues and Bugs:  [hraf-support@yale.edu](mailto:hraf-support@yale.edu)



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)